

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

DOW JONES | News Corp *****

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★★★★ \$5.00

DJIA 49395.16 ▼ 267.50 0.54%

NASDAQ 22682.73 ▼ 0.3%

STOXX 600 625.33 ▼ 0.5%

10-YR.TREAS. ▲ 2/32, yield 4.074%

OIL \$66.43 ▲ \$1.24

GOLD \$4,975.90 ▼ \$10.60

EURO \$1.1774

YEN 154.98

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Amazon.com** surpassed Walmart as the largest company by annual revenue, clocking \$716.9 billion in sales for its most recent full year, compared with Walmart's \$713.2 billion **A1**
- ◆ **Walmart** reported strong sales growth in its latest quarter as it continued to attract more shoppers of all income groups to its groceries and fast delivery service. **B1**
- ◆ **Oil prices** climbed and the Dow fell 0.5% as investors monitored the U.S. military buildup in the Middle East, a wariness that also helped depress both the S&P 500 and Nasdaq by 0.3%. **B1**
- ◆ **Blue Owl** said it is liquidating \$1.4 billion in assets to raise money to pay individuals who invested in some of its private-credit funds in their heyday but now want to get out. **B1**
- ◆ **Airbus** said it would deliver fewer aircraft than expected this year because of significant shortages of Pratt & Whitney engines. **B1**
- ◆ **Boeing** signed contracts to sell almost 100 jets to Vietnamese carriers in deals valued at over \$30 billion, signaling warming ties between the U.S. and Vietnam. **B2**
- ◆ **Nestlé** said it would sell its remaining ice cream business and consolidate operations around coffee, petcare, nutrition and food. **B1**
- ◆ **The attorney general** of West Virginia sued Apple, alleging the company allowed its iCloud platform to be used to store and distribute child sexual abuse material. **B4**

Worldwide

- ◆ **U.K. police** arrested Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, the former Prince Andrew, on suspicion of misconduct in public office, as revelations linked to Epstein roil British politics and the royal family. **A1**
- ◆ **Trump** is weighing an initial, limited strike on Iran to force it to meet his demands for a nuclear deal, a step that would fall short of a full-scale attack that could inspire a major retaliatory response. **A5**
- ◆ **Iran** is preparing for war should talks with the U.S. fail, deploying its forces, dispersing decision-making authority, fortifying its nuclear sites and expanding its crackdown on domestic dissent. **A5**
- ◆ **NASA** leaders said the agency disregarded crew safety by pushing ahead with the failed 2024 Starliner mission, which waylaid astronauts for months at the International Space Station. **A3**
- ◆ **The husband** of embattled Labor Secretary Lori Chavez-DeRemer is under investigation for an alleged sexual assault that took place at Labor Department headquarters in December, police said. **A4**
- ◆ **A court** in Seoul sentenced former South Korean President Yoon Suk Yeol to life in prison for leading an insurrection during a short-lived attempt to impose martial law on the country. **A7**
- ◆ **The Commission** of Fine Arts, made up of Trump appointees, approved his proposal to build a ballroom where the White House's East Wing once stood. **A4**

JOURNAL REPORT
Workplace Technology: We're training AI to be us. **R1-6**

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PHIL NOBLE/REUTERS

Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, King Charles III's younger brother, was released from Aylsham Police Station on Thursday after his arrest on suspicion of misconduct in public office.

Walmart Loses U.S. Crown As Top Company by Revenue

By SARAH NASSAUER
AND SEAN McLAIN

For nearly two decades Walmart has been the country's largest company by revenue, a status it touted to prospective hires, employees and its suppliers. It called itself a "Fortune 1" company. On Thursday, Walmart lost its crown.

Amazon.com—a 31-year-old company—surpassed 63-year-old Walmart as the country's largest company by annual revenue. Walmart had \$713.2 billion in sales in the year through Jan. 31, compared with Amazon's \$716.9 billion for its most recent full year, a narrow difference that has been years in the making.

It marks the rapid rise of Amazon from its beginnings as an online bookseller started in Jeff Bezos' garage to a behemoth seeking to dominate sectors from cloud computing, artificial intelligence and entertainment to online sales. For Walmart, it highlights the reality that Amazon's sales are growing faster than its own. Last year, Amazon's sales grew 12.4% while Walmart clocked 4.7% growth.

As Amazon grew over decades, Walmart had to change its business model to adapt, said Bill Simon, former Walmart U.S. chief executive through 2014. In that way, Walmart was "driving the bus and now they are riding the

bus," Simon said.

Walmart leadership prepared for years to lose the title, according to people familiar with the matter. Some were surprised it didn't happen faster. Top executives reframed the company's goals to more often focus on becoming "America's favorite place to shop," rather than the biggest or growing fast. At the company's start-of-the-year meeting for store leadership last week in Houston, signage promoted the idea of being the favorite. In past job listings, Walmart often touted the idea that working for

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◆ **Walmart sales** climb on grocery, online gains..... **B1**

U.K. Ex-Prince Arrested Amid Epstein Probe

King Charles says royal family backs full investigation of Andrew's conduct

LONDON—U.K. police arrested Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, the former Prince Andrew, on suspicion of misconduct in public office, as revelations linked to Jeffrey Epstein roil British politics and the royal family.

By David Luhnow,
Max Colchester
and Gareth Vipers

King Charles III said he had learned of the arrest of his younger brother with "deepest concern" but that the royal family supported a full investigation. He said: "Let me state clearly: The law must take its course."

Police didn't disclose the exact allegations they were investigating, but the arrest comes after disclosures about his dealings with Epstein that have dominated headlines in the U.K.

A cache of emails recently released by the U.S. Justice Department show Mountbatten-Windsor's personal and business interactions with the convicted sex offender were far more extensive and went on for far longer than previously known.

Mountbatten-Windsor was being questioned by police on Thursday and hasn't been charged. Police said Mountbatten-Windsor has been released under investigation.

The former prince has consistently denied any wrongdoing in relation to his dealings with Epstein—and didn't respond to requests for comment.

President Trump said the arrest was "very, very sad" and "so bad for the royal family." He praised King Charles

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Accomplice Was Set To Flip on Epstein—Then Went Dark

By KHADEEJA SAFDAR
AND CAITLIN OSTROFF

Jean-Luc Brunel was ready to turn on the man who had been his patron and partner. The French modeling scout was prepared to tell prosecutors what he knew about Jeffrey Epstein's sex trafficking.

Brunel was secretly negotiating in 2016 with lawyers representing Epstein's victims, according to newly released Justice Department files. Brunel's lawyer told them his client recruited girls for Epstein and had incriminating photographs. They discussed a date for Brunel to walk into the U.S. Attorney's office in New York—in exchange for immunity.

"One of Epstein's bfs, Jean Luc Brunel, has helped get girls. He is wanting to cooperate," according to handwritten notes taken by a federal prosecutor in

February 2016. "Brunel is afraid of being prosecuted."

And then Brunel went dark.

Epstein had discovered that negotiations with Brunel were taking place, the files show. On May 3, he fired off an email to Kathy Ruemmler, an attorney he corresponded with regularly. He wrote that Brunel was planning to go to the U.S. Attorney's office the following week and one of Brunel's friends had "asked for 3 million dollars so that Jean Luc would not go in."

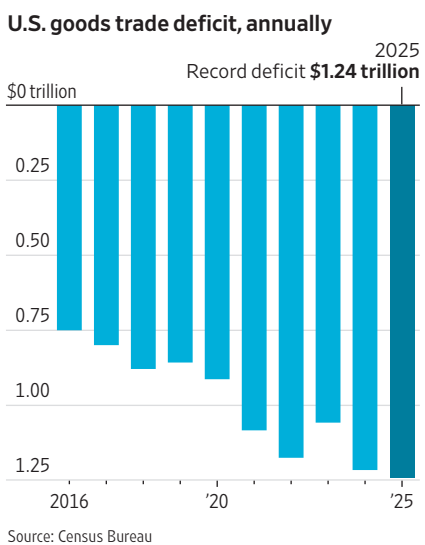
Epstein told Ruemmler that Brunel was afraid he would be arrested if he didn't show up. "I want to know more," Epstein wrote. He also dismissed Brunel's lawyer and his friend as "scammers" and cast doubt on their credibility.

Ruemmler responded hours later, asking Epstein to call and explain. The next day, she

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Imports to U.S. Hit Record

Imports to the U.S. grew to a record high in 2025, leaving the trade deficit little changed despite steep Trump administration tariffs aimed at closing trade gaps. The trade deficit in goods last year rose to a record \$1.241 trillion. Overall, imports last year were \$4.334 trillion, up about 5% from the prior record of \$4.136 trillion in 2024. **A2**



Businesses Retreat From Policies Of Making Boards More Diverse

By THEO FRANCIS

Anti-diversity activists are going after DEI policies for corporate boards, but a new analysis finds that companies have largely abandoned those goals already.

S&P 500 companies are adding women and minority directors no faster than they did a decade ago, shortly before diversity, equity and inclusion policies became more common across the corporate world, according to a Wall Street Journal analysis of

board data.

"It shows that all along this was expendable," said Doug Chia, president of consulting firm Soundboard Governance.

Companies adopted such policies in droves over the past decade in the face of pressure from institutional investors and states such as California to diversify their largely white and male boardrooms. Goldman Sachs, until a year ago, also mandated that companies have diverse boards as a criteria for the bank to take them public.

But as the political winds in the U.S. have shifted, companies have swiftly retreated. This week, the Journal reported that Goldman Sachs plans to drop a policy of considering candidate demographics—including race, gender, ethnicity and sexual orientation—when recruiting its own new directors.

Other companies have already done so. Just a quarter of S&P 500 companies had a policy last year of considering gender, racial and ethnic

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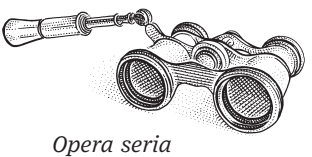
A Highbrow Culture War Rocks Venice's Opera House

Orchestra protests with al fresco concerts; fans throw leaflets to Verdi

By JAMES HOOKWAY

VENICE—Luca Salsi glowered and lunched his way around the stage, clutching his hand to his chest as he geared up for his death scene in "Simon Boccanegra," Verdi's opera about a pirate who becomes ruler of Genoa.

Behind the curtain, an even bigger drama is playing out, this time over who should run one of Italy's best-known opera houses: its glamorous, politically connected new musical director, or an orchestra peeved at not being consulted



Opera seria

on her appointment. Even the audience is picking sides in this highbrow culture war.

Act One kicked off last fall, when pianist and conductor Beatrice Venezi was announced as the next musical director of Teatro La Fenice.

Some opera critics welcomed the idea of a woman

leading the Venice opera for the first time. Venezi's supporters say the 35-year-old, who once appeared in Italian shampoo commercials, has the potential to open up the fusty world of opera to a whole new audience. Her four-year stint is due to begin in October.

For others, Venezi's resume is too thin to lead a theater that staged the premieres of no fewer than five of Verdi's operas; she has done much of her work overseas.

Worse, La Fenice's musicians say, she was selected

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INSIDE



FAZLY USMIL/EPH SHUTTERSTOCK

SPORTS

The women's hockey team and figure skater Alysa Liu win Olympic gold for the U.S. **A16**

TOMORROW



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MIKAELA SHIFFRIN